

Tonghua Li

PhD Candidate in Politics, University of York, United Kingdom

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RESEARCH AND TEACHING INTERESTS

International Relations/International Political Economy Theory and Practice | Constructivism | Political Discourse and Narratives | Trade Politics | US Foreign Policy | China in Global Politics | US-China Relations

EDUCATION AND QUALIFICATIONS

PhD in Politics , University of York, UK <i>Department of Politics and International Relations</i> - Thesis: <i>Constructing Trade Politics: Discourse, Framing, and Legitimation in US-China Relations in the Trump Era.</i> - Supervisors: Professor Tony Heron and Dr Tomaz M. Fares.	Oct 2023 – Jul 2027 (expected)
Associate Fellow of the Higher Education Academy (AFHEA), Advance HE	Oct 2026
MSc in International Relations (Distinction) , University of Glasgow, UK <i>School of Social and Political Sciences</i> - Dissertation: <i>Exploring the Role of NGOs in Governance from the Perspective of Chinese State-NGO Relations.</i> - Supervisors: Professor Jane Duckett and Dr Neil Munro.	Sept 2022 – Sept 2023
BSc in Agricultural Economics , Lincoln University (New Zealand) and Yunnan Agricultural University (China) <i>School of International Studies, joint degree programme</i> GPA: 3.8/4.0, ranked 1st of 90.	Sept 2018 – Jul 2022
Summer School in US-China Relations , University of California, Berkeley, USA	Jun – Aug 2019

PUBLICATIONS AND RESEARCH PAPERS

Forthcoming

Li, T., Heron, T. and Fares, T. M. "The Politics of Selective Green Legitimation in China-South America Agricultural Trade in the Trump 2.0 Era." *International Development Planning Review*.

Under Review

Li, T. "Trade, Power, and Discursive Instability: Trump's Trade Discourse as Political Practice." Under review at *New Political Economy*.

Li, T. "The Politics of Trade Framing: Policy Meaning and Escalation in US-China Relations under Trump." Under review at *The British Journal of Politics and International Relations*.

Li, T., Yan, Z. and Fares, T. M. "Between Global Growth and Domestic Stability: Discursive Contestation in China's Food Security Governance." Under review at *Global Studies Quarterly*.

Work in Progress

Li, T. "Narrating the US-China Trade Dispute: Ideas, Identity, and Official Discourse in Xinwen Lianbo." Planned for submission to *The China Quarterly* in 2027.

Li, T. "Emotional Scripts in Trump's Trade Politics: Ideas, Affect, and Discursive Construction." Planned for submission to *Review of International Studies* in 2027.

Li, T. "Water Politics under Power Asymmetries: Discourse Practice and Resource Governance in the Mekong River." Planned for submission to *Political Research Exchange* in 2027.

RESEARCH AND TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Seminar Tutor , University of York - Led seminars for 400+ undergraduate students and marked 500+ pieces of coursework. - Teach on five undergraduate modules in Politics, International Relations and Environment across three years. - Introduction to Global Politics (POL00015C), Spring 2026/27 (upcoming) - Global Challenges: From Theory to Practice (POL00012C), Autumn 2025/26 and 2026/27 - Research Skills and Project Design (ENV00048I), Spring 2025/26 - York Policy Lab (POL00016C), Spring 2024/25 - Introduction to Comparative Politics (POL00013C), Autumn 2024/25	May 2024 – present
Researcher , Stockholm Environment Institute	Oct 2023 – Nov 2025

- Researched food security and environmental sustainability amid US–China trade tensions, focusing on the resilience of global food systems during geopolitical crises.
- Coordinated events for the Sustainable Consumption and Production Research Group.
- Co-authored reports and short articles on global forestry politics and food security.

Teaching Assistant, Path Academy

Jun 2022 – Sept 2023

- Tutored 50+ students in IELTS writing and speaking, with individual feedback.
- Prepared literature reviews and collected data for a University of Pennsylvania course in political thought and international relations theory.

ACADEMIC CITIZENSHIP

Lead Organiser, [Global China Studies Early Career Researcher Network](#) ↗

Apr 2026 – present

- Established a global academic network that now connects 300+ China studies scholars.
- Convened the network's 2026 annual conference for 70+ scholars worldwide.
- Chaired four panels on *China and Multipolar Order*, *political economy of Development*, *state transformation and the Belt and Road*.
- Coordinate a regular webinar series (10+ sessions to date) open to researchers across countries and institutions.

GRANTS, SCHOLARSHIPS AND AWARDS

CSC–University of York Joint-Funded PhD Scholarship , £135,000	2023 – 2027
International Studies Association (ISA) 2027 Grant , US\$500	Oct 2026
Faculty of Social Sciences PGR Community Fund , University of York, £1,500	Apr 2026
Open Research Award , University of York, £400	Apr 2026
European Consortium for Political Research (ECPR) Grant , £500	Mar 2026
University-Level Scholarship (top 5%) , Yunnan Agricultural University, ¥3,000	Mar 2022
First Prize, FLTRP National English Speech Competition , China	Dec 2021
Outstanding Student (top 1%) , Yunnan Agricultural University	Jan 2020
First Place, UN COP15 Volunteer English Speaking Competition	Jan 2020

SELECTED CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

“The Configurational Politics of Trade Measures in Trump’s Foreign Policy: US Political Conditions for Chinese Restraint” European Consortium for Political Research (ECPR) General Conference, Kraków	Sept 2026
“Trade, Power, and Discursive Instability: Political Rationales in Trump’s Trade Policy” Political Studies Association (PSA) American Politics Conference, Oxford	Jun 2026
“Between Global Growth and Domestic Stability: Discursive Contestation in China’s Food Security Governance during the Fourteenth Five-Year Plan” British International Studies Association (BISA) Annual Conference, Brighton	Jun 2026
“Trade, Power, and Discursive Instability: Political Rationales in Trump’s Trade Policy” International Studies Association (ISA) 67th Annual Convention, Columbus	Mar 2026
“The Political Economy of Food Trade in the US–China Trade Dispute: Soybean and Biofuels Policy during Trump’s First Term” PPE Society Annual Conference, King’s College London	Jul 2025

RESEARCH METHODS AND SKILLS

Methods	Discourse analysis, thematic analysis, process tracing, interviews, questionnaire surveys, fuzzy-set qualitative comparative analysis, dictionary-based quantitative text analysis, GIS analysis.
Software	NVivo, Python, R, QGIS, SPSS
Languages	English (fluent), Chinese (native), Japanese (basic)

REFERENCES

Professor Tony Heron

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Professor of Political Economy
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Dr Tomaz M. Fares

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